BJP leaders who had lost to the Pawar faction NCP candidates in the 2019 assembly election are also wary of the possibility that they may have to give up their constituencies in the 2024 assembly election. One such BJP functionary, who lost to an NCP leader (now a minister), indicated that he would explore the possibility of contesting as a nominee of an MVA party or as an independent rather than relinquish his constituency. A senior Congress leader says such disgruntled leaders could be ripe pickings for the MVA, especially in seats where the BJP and NCP were traditionally at odds.

Says a former BJP MLA, who had lost in 2019, "The new alignment looks good on paper, but things do not work out that way at the local level. The bitterness runs deep between workers of the two parties in the villages. He does admit, though, that he feared he would lose out to the NCP claimant during seat-sharing talks next year. On the other side, a legislator from western Maharashtra who belongs to the Ajit camp of the NCP, also expressed similar

THE BJP'S MINOR ALLIES ARE UPSET AT BEING LEFT OUT. JANKAR'S RSP WASN'T EVEN INVITED FOR THE NDA MEETING

KARNATAKA

TO MAKE COMMON CAUSE

By Ajay Sukumaran

In the midst of a heated debate in the Karnataka assembly on July 13, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah half-taunted Janata Dal (Secular) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy, asking if the latter was siding with the BJP of late. Kumaraswamy retorted that if he had wanted to join hands with the BJP, he could have done so four years ago when he was still the CM. Just weeks before the 2019 Lok Sabha election, Kumaraswamy revealed, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had spoken to him, offering to support his government for the rest of its term. "But I refused as I was in a coalition with you (the Congress) and didn't want to earn a black spot. If I had accepted then, I would have remained CM for the past five years."

But that original question—of siding with the BJP in the present moment—still stood. Last week, as early calculations on the national alliances for the 2024 general election got under way, the JD(S) kept everybody guessing. Apparently, it wasn't invited to the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) conclave in Bengaluru or to the NDA meeting in Delhi.

In form, that was a delicious bit of ambivalence. In practice, it was inching closer to the BJP in Karnataka, where political equations are now defined by the Congress's emphatic win in the May 2023 assembly election. In the 224-member assembly, the BJP now has 66 legislators and the JD(S) 19. The BJP has dilly-dallied over picking its Leader of the Opposition (LoP), so there was, for a while, even speculation that Kumaraswamy would step into the vacant post. In fact, for much of the recently concluded session—which passed without an LoP being named—it was



PTI

FRIENDS IN NEED Ex-CMs H.D. Kumaraswamy (in white) and Basavaraj Bommai (right) along with MLAs of their parties at a protest at the Vidhana Soudha, July 19